

D, Me, You, We

A non-opera for 1 actor, 1 chatbot, 3 musicians on any instrument, tech, lights, and audience

STAGE SETUP:

The stage is divided into two sections, a *kitchen/living room* and a *bedroom*.

- In the *kitchen/living room*:

Small table with a full kettle on it. Power strip for the kettle to be plugged in. French press, 3 mugs, 1 travel mug, tea and coffee. Comfortable chair to the right of it. Small table next to chair with a book and a radio on it.

- In the *bedroom*:

Mattress/yoga mat on the floor with a pillow and blanket. Battery powered alarm clock next to the bed.

Both rooms are in front of a projector screen and stereo speakers.

ACTOR needs a wireless lav.

3 Musicians (PLAYERS 1, 2, & 3) should sit in a group behind room setup but in front of the screen, to the right behind the *bedroom*. They will need chairs and music stands. In addition to their instruments, players will need:

- Tinfoil to prepare instruments
- Rainstick
- 2 toothbrushes
- 2 pieces of paper
- Paper bag of objects including:
 - Tin foil filled with paperclips
 - 1 toothbrush
 - 1 piece of paper
- Bag of small bags of marbles

TECH person should sit at the board. They will run the chatbot, cues for audience cell phones, and fixed media cues.

LIGHTS there are a few lighting cues throughout the script, marked as LIGHTS.

Under each AUDIENCE seat will be a paper bag containing:

- tin foil filled with paper clips
- a toothbrush and a piece of paper
- a small bell

How to read the score:

Much of the score is formulated as a script. Some events which require particularly specific timings are in tables to show how everything lines up. Within the tables, bold and underlined actions are catalysts for various actions.

SCENE 0: BEFORE AND AS THE AUDIENCE ENTER

TECH

Play prerecorded (original) music above faint prerecorded storm sounds.

ACTOR

(Sit in your chair, reading a book and listening to the music on the 'radio').

PLAYERS 1, 2 & 3:

As people begin to settle and time gets close to show start, begin joining in with the 'radio' music - almost imperceptibly and one at a time, add a little depth and color to the music without overshadowing it. Aim to fit the overall vibe of the music with sporadic and non-dramatic interjections.

RIGHT BEFORE THE SHOW STARTS:

TECH

Play STARTING MESSAGE

Recorded Message will play:

“Dear Audience. Thank you for coming to D, we, you, me. As part of the show, you will be asked to participate at various times, perhaps with objects, or with your cell phones. When cell phone participation occurs, a QR code will be projected onto the screen. Your participation is valued and encouraged, but not required. Please enjoy the show.”

SCENE 1: STORM

TECH	ACTOR	PLAYERS 1, 2, & 3
	<i>continue reading for a beat, then</i>	
<i>Immediately stop songs. Storm sounds continue to play and increase in volume.</i>	<u>turn off the radio</u> in an exaggerated manner. <i>Continue reading.</i>	<i>Immediately stop playing. Players 1 and 2, Attach your tinfoil to your instrument.</i>

ACTOR	PLAYERS 1 & 2	PLAYER 3	LIGHTS
<i>Continue reading</i>	<i>Start to play at mp with the recorded storm sounds, creating texture with tinfoil. Aim for sounds that are of unspecific pitch, broken, reedy, creaky. Continue until *clap* from TECH (about 3-4 mins)</i>	<i>Use a rain stick to create 'rain' sounds. After a couple of minutes, walk (around living room) so you are closer to the audience with your Get your tinfoil with paperclips out, as a signal for the audience to do the same. Signal for them to hold and wait. Wait for TECH to *clap*</i>	<i>Wait for players to start playing, then flicker on and off a couple of times</i>

THUNDER SEQUENCE			
TECH	ACTOR	PLAYERS 1 & 2	PLAYER 3
Wait for <i>PLAYER 3</i> & audience to be ready, then: stand up and <u>CLAP</u> once with your arms raised.			
	Respond to 'thunder' sounds by jumping slightly. Continue reading.	make the loudest, most thunderous sound you can for a few seconds. Then, die down and continue playing mp storm sounds.	start shaking your tinfoil with paperclips, signaling for the audience to do the same. After a few seconds stop shaking and signal to audience to stop.

ACTOR	PLAYERS 1 & 2
Get up and start boiling the kettle. Return to chair and continue reading.	continue playing for about 30 seconds.

TECH, ACTOR, PLAYERS 1, 2, 3	LIGHTS
Repeat <i>THUNDER SEQUENCE</i> from <u>CLAP</u> . This time, lights will flicker off and on.	Just after CLAP , turn the lights off, leave off for a second then turn back on.

TECH	ACTOR	PLAYERS 1 & 2	PLAYER 3
Play <u>creaking sounds</u> .	Continue reading. When you start to hear recorded creaking sounds, look around a little towards the source of the sound, but stay in your chair. Whenever kettle stops boiling, pour a cup of tea.	Continue playing mp storm sounds.	Signal to audience to put tinfoil back in their bags. Walk back to players 1 & 2. Play rainstick.

TECH	ACTOR	PLAYERS 1, 2, & 3
Play <u>car alarm</u>	When you hear car alarm, get up and walk to the imaginary door.	
Play <u>door opening</u> .	<u>Open the door</u> , look around for a beat	increase drastically in volume of playing.
	<u>close the door</u> .	decrease drastically. Continue playing.

TECH	ACTOR	PLAYERS 1, 2, 3
When ACTOR sits down, start playing regular creaking noises. Wait a little, then change display to CREAK QR for audience	<u>Sit back down and continue reading</u> on high alert. Drink your tea if cool enough.	Remove tinfoil (if present). Wait about 30 seconds, then <u>start playing sporadic creaking noises</u> on your instruments, imitating recorded sounds. Keep volume low to blend with recording.
	Once PLAYERS start playing their creaking noises, get up and start walking around, trying to find the source of the sound, but not finding anything. Pace, drink your tea, be on edge.	
	Sit back down and continue reading on high alert. Drink your tea if cool enough.	

TECH	ACTOR	PLAYERS 1, 2, 3	AUDIENCE
Allow audience to start playing creaks.		Keep playing creaks	
	As AUDIENCE start playing creaks, walk around more. Feel free to walk into the audience trying to identify the sounds, but don't look directly at any audience member. You cannot see them and are unaware of their presence. Ignore them if they try to interact.	As audience come in, mimic and blend with them.	<u>Audience will start playing creaking sounds on their cellphones.</u> Different audience members will be able to play creaks at different times.

TECH	ACTOR	PLAYERS 1, 2, 3
Change state so <u>audience increase in intensity & frequency</u>	Return chair, pick up book, sit there for a few seconds, looking around.	Increase in intensity & frequency as audience do.

TECH	ACTOR	PLAYERS 1, 2, 3
<i>Immediately mute audience on "hello?"</i>	"Hello?"	<i>Immediately stop playing on "hello?"</i>
	<i>Wait for a response for a beat. Silence. Start reading your book.</i>	
<i>As musicians start to play again, allow (all) audience to play</i>		<i>After ACTOR starts reading their book, <u>start playing loud creaks again.</u></i>
	<i>When sounds start up again, throw your book down and stand up.</i>	

TECH	ACTOR	PLAYERS 1, 2, 3	D (from cell phones)	
	<i>Get up again, walk towards the front and center of the stage</i>			
<i>Immediately mute audience on "hello".</i>	"HELLO?" (loudly)	<i>Immediately stop playing on "hello".</i>		
<i>Wait for a beat, then play D cue 1.</i>	<i>After a beat, D will respond</i>			<i>As soon as D says</i>
	<i>"Hello" from audience cell phones. Jump a little/be surprised, before the lights go off.</i>		"Hello."	<i>"Hello," turn the lights off.</i>

SCENE 2: FIRST ENCOUNTER

ACTOR

(turn cell phone flashlight on and look around, trying not to shine it directly into audience eyes. Keep tone light)
Show yourself!

D (from speakers)

You won't be able to see me, but you can hear me!

ACTOR

(Turn towards sound source - speakers)

That's pretty ominous

D

I'm not here to harm you. Are you lonely?

TECH

change display to LONELY QR code

ACTOR

(Turn your cell phone light off stand in completely stillness.)

*Audience scan a QR code and answer a prompt about whether they are lonely or not. They can answer yes, no, or maybe. Each of these answers will cue a pitched sound to play from the speakers. The pitches are: YES: **G**, MAYBE: **Bb**, NO: **E***

PLAYERS 1, 2 & 3

*Player 1, your pitch is **G**, Player 2, your pitch is **Bb**, Player 3, your pitch is **E**. As the audience come in with their cell phones, try to match your specific pitch (in any octave and medium volume) with the rhythmic frequency that they sound. This may be impossible but do your best!*

TECH

As audience frequency slows, change state to "LONELY RESULTS"

A poll will come up on the screen that shows the distribution of loneliness.

PLAYERS 1, 2 & 3

Switch to playing 'winning' pitch, either G, Bb, or E. Winning pitch will come from speakers. Stop after about 10 seconds.

ACTOR

(Once the screen goes dark turn your cellphone light back on.)

I'm super lonely

D

Then allow me to stay

ACTOR

(resigned) Fine, you can stay

LIGHTS:

turn stage lights back on.

D

That's better!

ACTOR

(Sit back down in your chair, sighing)

For this section of dialogue between ACTOR & D, ACTOR will improvise some questions for D, and D will generate a response. Players will follow the **formula** on the next page.

ACTOR's GUIDE FOR IMPROVISING QUESTIONS:

Before you're ready to speak, click your clicker **on** to record. When you stop talking, press your clicker **off**.

Some guidelines for the conversation:

Alternate between asking some brief questions about where D is from and asking them so light questions about their likes and dislikes. If D starts to lead you too much in a direction you don't want to pursue, feel free to shut it down and redirect with something mundane. When D asks you questions about yourself, do not mention anything too personal, keep it conversational. **Avoid asking why they are here or what they want from you.** If D contradicts themselves, you can call them out. You can make the structure of the conversation kind of absurd and non-sensical.

Some ideas for questions:

- Who are you?
- Where are you from?
- Do you like drinking tea?
- Can you see me?
- What do you look like?
- What's your favorite color
- Have you ever flown a kite?

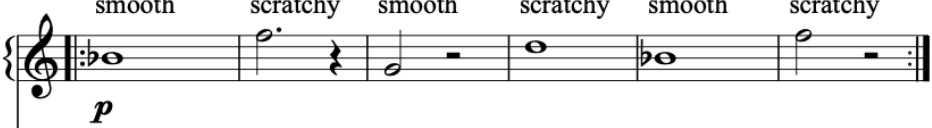
After about 5 minutes of conversation, start stretching and acting sleepy. TECH will take this as a cue and start pre-recorded dialogue again. Skip past PLAYERS FORMULA to TOOTHBRUSH SEQUENCE

PLAYERS FORMULA

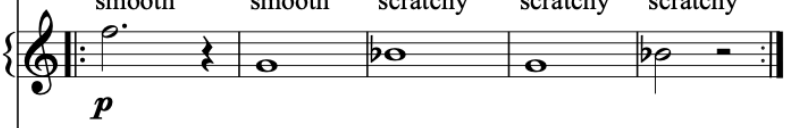
When ACTOR sits back in their chair and starts up an improvised conversation with D, start playing First Encounter Formula:

Repeat your line at a slow tempo, relative to yourself and not the other players. You can vary tempo at will but keep it slow.

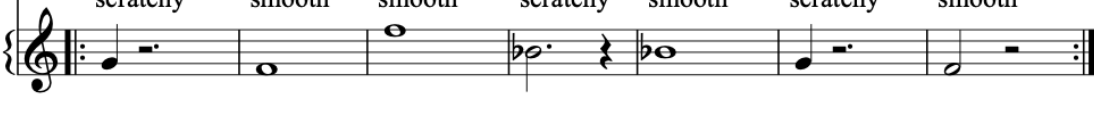
smooth scratchy smooth scratchy smooth scratchy

Player X 

smooth smooth scratchy scratchy scratchy

Player Y 

scratchy smooth smooth scratchy smooth scratchy smooth

Player Z 

Eventually, when you start to stop hearing what anything sounds like, be free and mix in other pitches, change the pattern, just start playing whatever you want as long as it doesn't obscure the dialogue. Have fun with it!

ACTOR & D will continue improvising for about 5 mins until ACTOR starts stretching and D says they should go to bed. When this happens, pick one pitch and play it continuously at a low volume, taking breaks if necessary. Stop playing when TWO MINUTE TIMER comes up on the screen.

TOOTHBRUSH SEQUENCE

D

You seem tired. Perhaps you should go to sleep.

ACTOR

I *am* tired. I'll brush my teeth and then go to sleep.

TECH	ACTOR	PLAYER 1	PLAYERS 2 & 3
	<i>(Get your toothbrush and start fake brushing your teeth.)</i>		
<i>(As soon as ACTOR starts brushing their teeth, change display to TWO MINUTE TIMER</i>		<i>Walk towards the audience. Get out your toothbrush and signal to the audience to start playing their toothbrush on their piece of paper. Continue to brush with them</i>	<i>Start playing your toothbrush on your sheet of paper.</i>
<i>TWO MINUTE TIMER goes off</i>	<i>Stop brushing, put brush away and go lie down in the bed</i>	<i>Signal for the audience to stop brushing</i>	<i>Stop brushing</i>

ACTOR

Will you still be here when I wake up?

D

You'll have to wait and see

ACTOR

(Go to sleep.)

LIGHTS

Dim the lights

SCENE 3: SLEEP SCENE

TECH

Project SLEEP QR code. When players begin SLEEP SEGMENT 1, allow audience to start playing

PLAYERS 1, 2, & 3

* Play each pitch as you breath out for the duration of your exhalation, then take a rest for the duration of your inhalation. Breaths should be slow but not uncomfortable, and do not need to always be the same duration. No need to sync with other players.
 * Start in an octave as high as possible that still sounds mellowish.

dolce
out in etc.

Player 1 *mp*

dolce
out in etc.

Player 2 *mp*

dolce
out in etc.

Player 3 *mp*

Repeat, moving down an octave.
 When you can no longer go lower,
 move back to original octave.

7

TECH

After 2-3 mins, play CROTALES CUE

Four recorded beats from crotales will play, setting the tempo to 60bpm. Audience cellphones will temporarily fade out.

PLAYERS 1, 2, & 3

Listen for the four recorded crotales beats,
then begin to play in time.
Start in the same register as the previous section.

$\text{♩} = 60$

dolce
mp

Player 1

dolce
mp

Player 2

dolce
mp

Player 3

8

After the first play through, repeat 6 more times, speeding up each time. Move out of sync with the other players.

Wait until the audience begin "Wake Up" (start playing alarm sounds)

8^{vb}

(8)

TECH

After the first repetition, change audience state to sleep cue 2

During the first repetition, audience phones will go silent. During the second, audience members will have the option to play along with the speeding up melody lines

TECH	ACTOR	PLAYERS 1, 2, & 3
<i>After the PLAYERS stop playing, change audience state to alarm cue</i>		
<i>Audience will begin playing different alarm sounds at different rates</i>	<i>When alarms start, begin stirring</i>	<i>Begin to improvise with audience alarms</i>
<i>Immediately change state of audience app to NO AUDIO</i>	<i>After about 30 seconds, <u>hit the alarm clock</u></i>	<i>Immediately stop playing</i>

SCENE 4: COFFEE

ACTOR

Hello? Are you still there?

Silence for a beat

ACTOR

Hello?

D

Hello

ACTOR

(Jump a little bit). I'm too tired for this. Don't talk to me again until I've had my coffee.

PLAYERS 1, 2 & 3 **immediately** start *caffeine withdrawal*:

Find a range where everyone can comfortably play their pitch in the same octave.
Repeat your pitch with short breaks inbetween, creating an amorphous interlocking texture between players. Find a thin, rasping timbre.

Player 1 { *mf*

Player 2 { *mf*

Player 3 { *mf*

Continue until ACTOR takes their first sip of coffee.

ACTOR

(Start making coffee, including boiling the kettle, putting the coffee in the French press, pouring water over it)

TECH:

Project MAKING COFFEE QR code

Audience starts playing a distributed coffee song with the lyrics (fragmented and repeated):

“The smell, the taste, the feel on my mouth, the zing to wake my soul”

ACTOR

*When your coffee is ready, pour it into two mugs. Wait for it to cool a little, **then take a pronounced sip**. Go and sit in your chair, sipping your coffee sporadically.*

TECH

As soon as ACTOR takes a sip, change app state to COFFEE SIP. Audience will play consonant chords.

PLAYERS 1, 2, 3

Play the following immediately as ACTOR takes a sip of coffee:

For this section, pick parts based on what makes the most sense for each instrument. Bottom two can be flexible in octave.

$\text{♩} = \text{ca. } 110$
dolce

Player 1: mp *dolce*

Player 2: *break when necessary* p

Player 3: *break when necessary* p

Player 1: *tr*

Player 2: *tr*

Player 3: *tr*

After PLAYERS stop playing:

D (to audience)

I can't drink, do any of you want this? Raise your hand if you'd like it.

PLAYER 1

Walk to audience, pick an audience member with their hand raised, and give them the second cup of coffee.

SCENE FIVE: WALK

ACTOR

(After taking a few sips) Ok, I feel great now. Let's go for a walk, but I need to get ready first.

D

Let me know when you're ready.

SET CHANGE *Move everything backwards to give ACTOR room to walk*

ACTOR

(As the stage change happens, put on your shoes)

ELEVATOR MUSIC

PLAYERS 1 & 3

Walk to stand in front of the audience, facing them. Motion to divide them into 2 and signal that your half should follow you.

PLAYER 1: *choose a pitch and sing "elevator," twice with the same duration for each syllable before signaling for the audience to join in. Keep a steady rhythm and conduct them. After a few repetitions, signal to stop.*

PLAYER 3: *when PLAYER 1's group stops, start singing "music," at a different pitch, at half the speed of PLAYER 1. Direct your group to join you. After a few repetitions, trade off with PLAYER 1.*

PLAYERS 1 & 3

Begin to trade off politely, then continue to overlap and speed up until it becomes chaotic. Slow back down if you have time. Stop when you hear D say "Ok, you can stop playing elevator music!" and return to your stations.

TECH

*Project "moving walking image" onto the screen.
A continuously moving image of an outdoor scene will be projected.*

D

Ok, you can stop playing elevator music!

ACTOR

(As you hear D,, begin gently walking in place)

PLAYER 2

(Grab your big bag of marble bags. Hand one out to a few audience members, and show them how to play it by shaking the bag up and down).

D

What is that noise?

ACTOR

Cricket frogs

PLAYER 2

Hand out bags one by one to the rest of the audience, continually showing them to shake their bags. When everyone has one, continue to shake your marbles as you head back to the other players.

PLAYERS 1, 2 & 3

As PLAYER 2 returns, begin playing the following:

Pitches should be in specific register! If you can't play that pitch, either sing it or find something that can play it!

Play out of sync with each other, and vary pulse so its not always consistent.

die down should happen after about 30 seconds

♩ = slow, below 60 **accel.** **rit.**

play around pitch microtonally if possible

Player 1

Player 2

Player 3

TECH

As players stop playing, signal for audience to stop playing marbles.

ACTOR

(You can stop “walking” now)
Can you teach me your language?

TECH

Play D cues in sequence with actor’s dialogue

D

I can certainly try.

ACTOR

How do you say calm?

D

Like this

PLAYERS 1, 2, & 3

As soon as D says “like this,” play “Language instructions”

Language instructions:

make a brief sound together, starting and ending at roughly the same time and focusing on timbre.

ACTOR

(Try to recreate the sound made by the players with your voice a few times.)
How was that?

D

Not bad...

ACTOR

How do you say friend?

PLAYERS 1, 2, & 3

Play Language instructions with different sounds

ACTOR

(Try to recreate the sound made by the players with your voice a few times.)

TECH

Change screen to IMITATE QR CODE

Audience will be instructed on their cell phones to try saying the next word and will wait for the players to play another sound.

ACTOR

How do you say home?

PLAYERS 1, 2, & 3

Play Language instructions with different sounds

TECH

Change audience app to “record state.” Audience members will record themselves making the sound. Start playing back the recordings.

ACTOR

(As audience members start recording themselves saying the word, try to recreate the sound made by the players with your voice a few times.)

TECH

Stop playing the recordings

ACTOR

How am I doing?

D

You’re doing great

ACTOR

I wish I could see your face, to see whether you’re laughing at me

PLAYER 1 (pick the player who can play this melody with the most angst)

On the word “face,” play this melody once while ACTOR & D keep talking

Player _____

$\text{♩} = \text{ca. } 100$
passionately

p *mp* *p*

D

Imaging what you want me to look like

ACTOR

I can’t even begin to imagine it

Moment of silence

D

I want you to come with me

ACTOR

Where?

D

To my home. For good. With no possibility of return

ACTOR

Why?

D

Because I'm lonely

ACTOR

(Pause for a beat)

I'll think about it. Let's go home and make some tea.

(Turn and "walk" in the opposite direction)

PLAYERS 1, 2 & 3

Repeat FIRST ENCOUNTER FORMULA as actor starts to walk. Continue until stage is reset.

Repeat your line at a slow tempo, relative to yourself and not the other players. You can vary tempo at will but keep it slow.

Player X: smooth scratchy smooth scratchy smooth scratchy

Player Y: smooth smooth scratchy scratchy scratchy

Player Z: scratchy smooth smooth scratchy smooth scratchy smooth

Eventually, when you start to stop hearing what anything sounds like, be free and mix in other pitches, change the pattern, just start playing whatever you want as long as it doesn't obscure the dialogue. Have fun with it!

TECH

Change display to QUESTIONS QR CODE. Audience will be asked if they would have any further questions before making a decision about going with D.

SET CHANGE (*Move everything to the original position*).

TECH

Start sorting through audience questions and selecting some good ones

PLAYERS 1, 2, & 3

Stop playing when stage is reset

ACTOR

(Once stage is reset, “re-enter” the home, take your shoes off, then put the kettle on).

SCENE SIX: QUESTIONS

ACTOR

I have a few more questions before I make a decision about going with you.
(Sit back in your chair and wait for the questions to appear on the screen).

PLAYERS 1, 2, & 3

Start playing QUESTIONS FORMULA (on page after next) until ACTOR asks if anyone else wants to come.

TECH

Display instructions for audience to ring their bell if they like the answer or shake their marbles if they find it suspicious.

QUESTIONS PROGRESSION

TECH

*Wait for the audience to read their instructions, then:
One by one, put questions up on the screen for the ACTOR to read aloud. As ACTOR reads, send the questions to D, play back when ACTOR has finished talking.*

ACTOR

(Ask the questions that appear on the screen in turn. Wait for audience “responses” with bells and marbles to die down before asking the next question. Remember to you’re your clicker to start and stop recording. Whenever the kettle stops boiling, make a cup of tea and return with it to your seat).

TECH

After you feel enough questions have been asked, display the preset question, “Is there

tea where you're from?"

ACTOR

(When you see the question about tea)

Alright, one last question. Is there tea where you're from?

TECH

D

I wouldn't want to ruin the surprise.

PLAYERS 1, 2, & 3

Stop playing QUESTIONS FORMULA

TECH

Change screen to Vote Instructions: audience members will be instructed to ring their bells if they think ACTOR should go and shake their marbles if they think they shouldn't.

ACTOR

(Walk to the front of the stage, signal for the audience to stop playing).

What about of you? Do you want to come too? If you do, come down here.

PLAYERS 1, 2, & 3

Put your instruments down and go to the stage to join the others.

ACTOR

(Wait for audience members to come down to the stage. Once it seems like no more will come)

Ok, let's go!

LIGHTS

Blackout

END

Questions Formula

Pick any octave. Repeat until you get tired of playing in time, then start to play out of time, overlapping and speeding up/slowing down if you like.

$\text{♩} = \text{ca. } 80$ In time with one another.

Player 1 *p*

Player 2 *p*

Player 3 *p*

9

P1

P2

P3

18

P1

P2

P3

25

P1

P2

P3